CHAPTER 5

UNLOCKING YOUR LEADERSHIP ADAPTABILITY THROUGH CAREER DIVERSIFICATION

Summary

This chapter explains how leader self-complexity can enhance adaptability and how high-quality, diverse career experiences can foster this self-complexity. To support your development, the chapter presents two self-assessment tools that allow you to evaluate your level of leader self-complexity and your career experiences, helping you better understand your unique characteristics. The insights and strategies outlined in this chapter are instrumental not only for individual leadership development but also for those seeking to promote leadership growth within their organizations.

Chapter Outline

Introduction

Leader Self-Complexity, Adaptability, and Career Experiences

- What Is Self-Complexity?
- What Is Leader Self-Complexity?
- Leader Self-Complexity and Adaptability
- Diversifying Career Experience and Leader Self-Complexity
- Assessing the Diversity of Your Career Experiences

Summary

Learning Outcomes

By the end of the chapter, readers should:

1. Understand what leader self-complexity is and why it is important for adaptability.

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2. Be aware that leader self-complexity can be developed through high-quality, diverse career experiences.

3. Be able to use the two self-assessment tools provided in this chapter to evaluate your leader self-complexity and career experiences.

4. Be able to use the two self-assessment tools provided in this chapter to design your own leadership development plan.

Case Questions

1. Based on the case study of Jane and Sarah, explain why Jane's leader self-concept is considered complex, whereas Sarah's leader self-concept is considered simple. What are the key differences in their leader self-concepts?

2. If you were in Sarah's position, what steps would you take to develop your leader self-complexity? Outline a plan that includes specific strategies and experiences to help you broaden and deepen your leader self-concept.

3. Identify and discuss the evidence presented in the chapter that supports the idea that Jane is a more adaptive leader compared to Sarah. How does Jane's complex leader self-concept contribute to her adaptability?

Personal Development Activities

In this chapter, we have provided two self-assessment tools (see Tables 5.1, 5.2, and 5.3) to help you evaluate your current leader self-complexity and career experiences. These tools are not only for assessment but can also serve as powerful instruments for your personal development. After reading this chapter, you may wish to further develop your leader self-complexity through intentional career experiences. The activity outlined below is designed to guide you in this process.

Review Leadership Roles: Start by revisiting the list of leadership roles in Table 5.1. Identify any aspects of your leader self-concept that you would like to add or further develop in the

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future. As you do this, consider which aspects are achievable in the short term (within one year or less) and which may require a longer-term focus.

Set Development Goals: Once you have identified the leadership roles you wish to develop, write down the role labels at the top of a piece of paper. Under each role, list the corresponding characteristics (such as traits, skills, and self-regulation strategies) that you aim to cultivate. You can use Table 5.2 as a starting point for this step. Additionally, think about the types of experiences that could help you achieve these developmental goals. The questions on "diversity of work experience" in Table 5.3 can provide further guidance.

Example: If you want to incorporate the role of "team builder" into your leader self-concept, begin by listing this role at the top of your page. Underneath, you might identify traits like "effective communication," "empathy," and "cultural competence." Next, consider experiences that could facilitate the development of these traits. For instance, in the short term, you might set a goal to have one meaningful conversation with a team member each week. In the mid-term, you could aim to work with different departments within your organization. For a long-term goal, you might seek opportunities to work in diverse cultural settings or industries.

Evaluate Development Opportunities: As you progress in your career, you will encounter various opportunities that could help you achieve your developmental goals. Before committing to these opportunities, use the questions on "quality of work experience" in Table 5.3 to evaluate them critically. For example, before relocating to another department or industry, consider whether the new experience will offer you autonomy, provide clear feedback, and ensure adequate support.

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Create a Personal Action Plan: Finally, organize the goals and strategies you've identified under each leadership role label. Use this as your personal action guide on your journey to becoming a more effective leader.

By following these steps, you will be well-equipped to systematically develop your leader self-complexity, aligning your career experiences with your personal growth objectives.

Table 5.1 Roles potentially held by leaders

[b]**Mentor** Facilitates the development and growth of the employees.	[b]**Innovator** Is creative and envisions, encourages, and facilitates change.	[b]**Monitor** Checks on the progress and quality of the work and evaluates the performance of members.	[a]**Negotiator** Negotiates agreements and coordinates related activities with other parts of the organization or with outsiders.
[c]**Facilitator** Delegates responsibility and authority to employees and involves employees in making important work-related decisions.	[a]**Spokesperson** Transmits information and expresses value statements to people outside their organizational subunit.	[a]**Resource allocator** Exercises their authority to allocate resources such as money, personnel, material, equipment, facilities, and services.	[c]**Competitor** Focuses on the competition by emphasizing the need to compete, developing a competitive focus, and insisting on beating outside competitors.
[e]**Team builder** Fosters teamwork, develops a positive team atmosphere, facilitates collective learning, and builds team cohesion.	[c]**Motivator** Motivates members by praising, providing recognition, and recommending appropriate rewards, and inspires people to exceed expectations	[d]**Planner** Develops short-term plans for the work and determines the action steps and resources needed to accomplish a project or activity.	[c]**Producer** Shows a hard work ethic by showing an appetite for hard work, demonstrating full exertion on the job, and modeling an intense work effort.

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[f]Communicator	[b]Broker	[b]Coordinator	[b]Director
Relates messages between subordinates and top management, interprets and communicates the strategies set out by top management, and provides relevant information to the executive committee to facilitate strategy formulation.	Acquires resources and maintains the unit's external legitimacy through the development, scanning, and maintenance of a network of external contacts.	Provides tight project management, maintains the structure, does the scheduling, coordinating, and problem-solving, and sees that rules and standards are met.	Engages in goal setting and role clarification, sets priorities and deadlines for important aspects of the work, and establishes clear expectations for individuals.

Note: [a]adapted from Mintzberg (1975), [b]adapted from Denison et al. (1995), [c]adapted from Lawrence et al. (2009), [d]adapted from Yukl (2012), [e]adapted from Cameron et al. (2014), adapted from [f] Rensburg et al. (2014).

Table 5.2 Traits frequently associated with leaders

Patient	Visionary	Analytical	Goal-oriented
Considerate	Innovative	Incorruptible	Results-oriented
Compassionate	Creative	Impartial	Mature
Empathetic	Imaginative	Transparent	Courageous
Helpful	Encouraging	Task-focused	Bold
Caring	Initiative	Logical	Energetic
Kind	Enthusiastic	Calm	Sociable
Receptive to criticism	Motive arouser	Organized	Dedicated

Table 5.3 Work experiences

Diversity of Work Experience

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1. How many different organizations/companies have you worked in? Have these all been within the same industry, or do you have cross-industry experience?

2. How many different functional areas/departments have you worked in?

3. How many different teams or work groups have you been part of?

4. How many different countries or in settings with different cultural backgrounds have you worked in?

5. How many unusual or especially demanding work assignments that pulled you out of your comfort zone have you had?

Quality of Work Experience

To what extent have your varied work experiences:

1. allowed you autonomy?
2. provided you with clear feedback?
3. left you feeling supported in your actions?

Links to Other Chapters

In this chapter, we learn that the self is a complex system, with our attention being limited, allowing us to focus on only a few things at a time. At any given moment, only a portion of our "self " is in "active mode," guiding our thoughts and behaviors. For a more detailed explanation of this selection process and its impact on the knowledge we can readily access, please refer to Lord et al., Chapter 8 of this book.

Key Reading

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Day, D. V., & Lance, C. E. (2004). Understanding the development of leadership complexity through latent growth modeling. In D. V. Day, S. J. Zaccaro, & S. M. Halpin (Eds.), *Leader development for transforming organizations* (pp. 61–90). Lawrence Erlbaum Associates.

Further Reading

Hannah, S. T., Woolfolk, R. L., & Lord, R. G. (2009). Leader self-structure: A framework for positive leadership. *Journal of Organizational Behavior, 30*(2), 269– 290. https://doi.org/10.1002/job.586

Lord, R. G., Hannah, S. T., & Jennings, P. L. (2011). A framework for understanding leadership and individual requisite complexity. *Organizational Psychology Review, 1*(2), 104– 127. https://doi.org/10.1177/2041386610384757

Other Recommended Sources

Gottfredson, R. (2023, May 3rd). *Areas to improve our complexity.* [Video]. YouTube. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=9Faw-OwVO0c

Gottfredson, R. (2023, August 3rd). *Leaders: You need to elevate your complexity to effectively navigate complexity.* [Video]. YouTube. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=GLgyulOc6CU

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